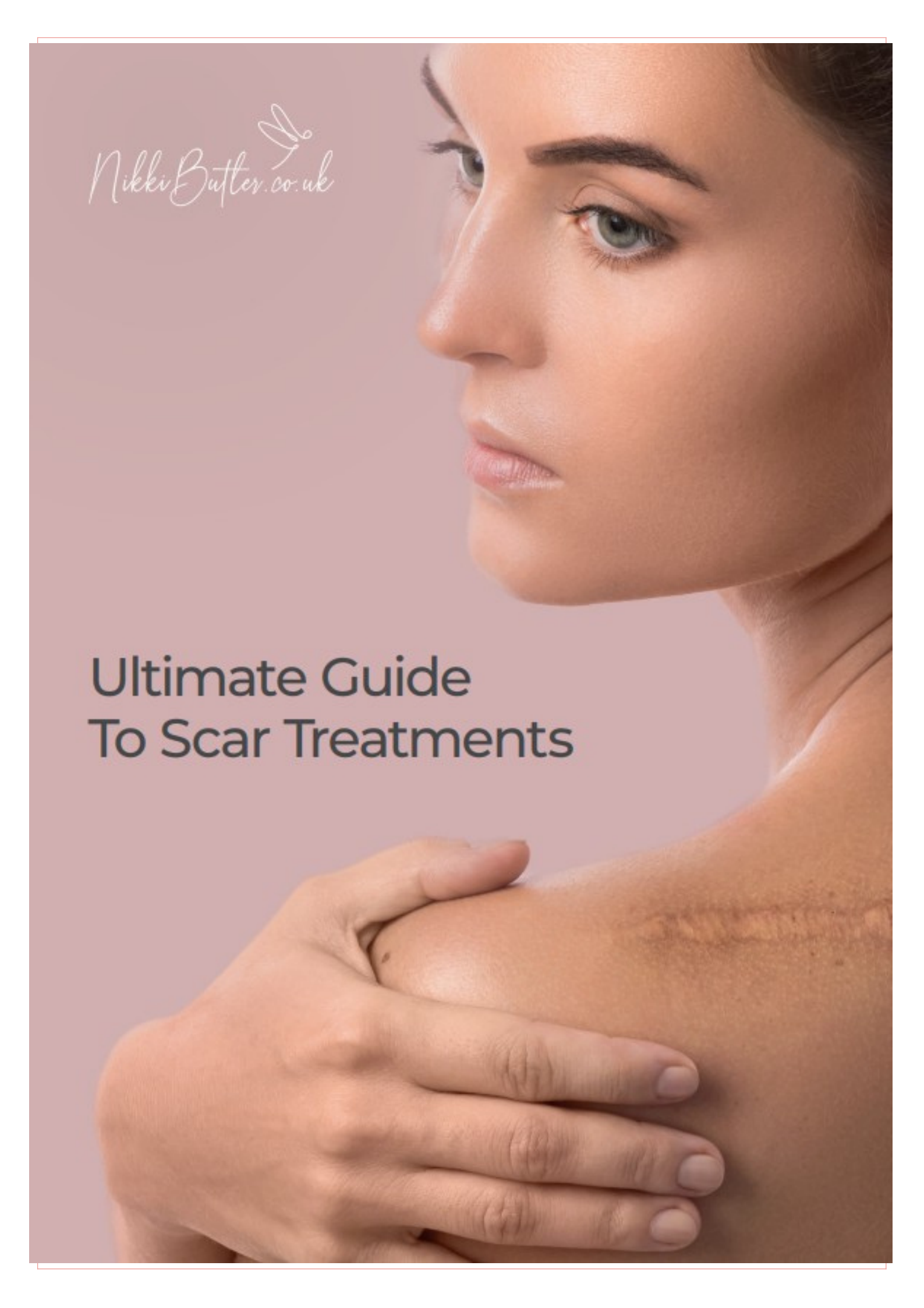


A close-up, profile view of a woman's face and shoulder. She has light skin and green eyes. Her hand is resting on her left shoulder, which features a prominent, raised, horizontal scar. The background is a soft, out-of-focus light pink.

NikkiButter.co.uk

Ultimate Guide To Scar Treatments

Ultimate Scar Guide

Welcome to your **ULTIMATE SCAR GUIDE**, for scars under 12 months old. This guide also applies to scars that are up to 2 years old, as some scars can take longer to heal.

I only offer treatments on scars that have reached the end of your natural healing process, as I believe it's important to let your body do what it does best – and that is to heal you.

Interrupting your natural healing process can be detrimental long term.

If you are in the early stages of healing, then there are some things you can do to help your scars, as you heal.

Once you've finished the natural healing process, we will be able to look at treatments to help improve the scars that you have.



A WHISTLE-STOP TOUR OF THE HEALING PROCESS

I say improve and not remove, because we can't completely remove scarring, but we can significantly improve it.

Scars can really make us feel self-conscious, I have many – and I certainly know the distress that significant scarring can cause. Having had multiple surgeries and a serious childhood accident, I can certainly relate to the impact that scarring can have on your confidence.

I just want to say that I think you're brave in reaching out for treatment because many scars carry emotional and mental trauma too. I never underestimate this side of things, so please know that I understand, and I'll support you through your treatment program with me.

There are several scar treatments that can really help to improve your scars, and often, a combined approach is the most effective. And, as the largest organ of your body (yes, your skin is an organ!), it's entirely unique to you, and therefore your treatment program will be unique to you.

Before we go any further, let's have a look at how we end up with scars. We will also look at factors that affect your body's ability to heal, and some things you can do to help your skin, at various stages of healing.

I am always fascinated by wound healing, and how incredible your body is at healing itself.



THE 5 STAGES OF HEALING

STAGE 1 - You have a wound – the skin is damaged and you're bleeding. Your body is SO CLEVER that it springs into action within seconds – and your blood starts to clot, to stop the bleeding and seal the wound site. This is a good kind of blood clot – as it's an immediate seal over the wound. This is known as haemostasis.



STAGE 2 - We swiftly move into the scabbing stage. Platelets, which are clotting cells in the blood, form a plug, to stop the wound from continuing to bleed. Your body also produces a protein called fibrin, which is like glue – keeping the wound site sealed. From here, we move into the next stage.



THE 5 STAGES OF HEALING

STAGE 3 - Inflammation: This is where your body really jumps into healing mode, now the wound site is healed. The first thing it does is it allows the blood vessels around the wound site to expand – increasing blood flow to the area.

Your body is very clever and can immediately detect where to send more energy and effort, to help repair you.

Your skin around the wound site will look red/pink and may well feel a little warm – don't worry – this is a sign that help has arrived!

White blood cells jump on in too, helping to fight infection, they are fighting off any nasties. You might see a clear-ish fluid too, that's perfectly normal – shows your body has its warriors in place, to protect you! The white blood cells are called macrophages, if you'd like to know the fancy name.



THE 5 STAGES OF HEALING

STAGE 4 - Rebuilding or the technical term is Proliferation. This is where your body starts to repair and produces another protein called collagen.

The type of collagen that your body produces in the wound healing process, differs from the type of collagen we have in healthy skin.

With wound healing, it sends your body into a state of 'emergency', so it acts quickly to repair you, so the type of collagen and the quality is different – to help you repair.

The collagen produced is the scaffolding for other cells to be built on, and as your body is repairing and regenerating, you may notice your scars are red/pink and, in many cases, raised.

This is all perfectly normal, and a sign your body is doing its job really well.



STAGE 5 - The Final stage is Maturation. This is the stage that takes place after the initial wound healing and foundations have been laid. During this time, you might find that your scars are still pink in colour, particularly after exercising, having a bath – or raising your body temperature. You may also find they feel a little itchy! Most scars take around 12 months to heal, but some can take longer.

There are several things that can affect wound healing – which I'll touch on next.



WHEN CAN MY SCARS BE TREATED?

I recommend starting treatment, once you have been through the natural healing process.

In my experience, it's not a good idea to interrupt your body in its natural healing state. I recommend assessing your scars for treatment, once they are white in colour, this will enable us to see what you are left with, once your body considers you fully healed. It will also help me to assess how your skin naturally heals and consider the most suitable form of treatment for you.

I'd recommend booking a consultation, once your scars are white. Whilst everyone heals differently, a guideline would be 9-12 months minimum for your body and 1 year for your face.

PLEASE don't be tempted to start treatment whilst you're still healing! I know it's hard when you desperately want to improve your scars, but you could be doing more harm than good. I have had numerous people that I refused to treat too early, and they went somewhere else and have ended up with more scarring, or post-inflammatory hyperpigmentation.

Please be patient, there are treatments that can help you, at the right time.



WHAT TO DO IF YOUR SCARS ARE STILL HEALING

CAN I DO ANYTHING TO HELP SPEED UP HEALING?

Well, yes you can!

Here are my top tips for supporting healthy wound healing:

1: LIFESTYLE. Stress and lack of sleep are the enemies of wound healing. If you are stressed, then you will have elevated cortisol and adrenaline levels in your system. When your body has excess cortisol, it essentially tells your body that you are in a dangerous situation – and its focus is to keep you safe. As a result, your body diverts energy away from what it considers ‘nonessential’ processes, often affecting your skin, hair, nails, and digestive system– the result, your wounds will not heal as well.

When it comes to lack of sleep, you’re in trouble – as the body repairs and regenerates overnight, whilst you are sleeping. If you aren’t sleeping well, then you aren’t allowing your body to heal and repair sufficiently. My advice – focus on improving your sleep and reducing your stress, as much as you can. There are many guides to a healthy bedtime routine, and stress reduction out there.



WHAT TO DO IF YOUR SCARS ARE STILL HEALING

Here are the **THREE** things I find helpful:

1. I have a set bedtime and pre-bedtime routine. I don't use my phone for an hour before bed – this helped me massively. I also get up at the same time every day. We have a natural circadian rhythm; I'd recommend doing some research on this – to find what works for you.
2. I start and finish my day with a gratitude journal. Nothing long – I use The 6 Minute Diary. 3 minutes in the morning and 3 in the evening. Gratitude was the single most effective thing in improving my sleep and stress levels.
3. I practice breathing techniques when I am stressed. You don't have to look for long windows of time to meditate, just 5-10 cycles of calm, controlled breathing with your eyes shut can be incredibly powerful. It tricks your brain into thinking you're calm.



HEALING FROM WITHIN

2: DIET AND NUTRITION. As your skin is your largest organ, everything you do from the inside out will help it. This is never more important than when you're recovering from injury or illness. You need to nourish your skin from within, to help promote healing.

Here are my top tips for supporting your healing from within.

1. VITAMIN C - Take a high-level vitamin C supplement with zinc. Vitamin C is essential for healthy collagen production, and zinc supports wound healing and reduces inflammation in your body – critical for repair. Eat foods that are rich in Vitamin C, such as berries, oranges, sweet potatoes, papaya, and pumpkins/squashes.

2. PROTEIN - Make sure you're eating good sources of protein at every meal. Protein is important for the health of your skin and collagen production. If you're struggling to find protein sources, then there are some great protein powders available. I personally love *Her Free Soul* and *Purition*.

3. VITAMIN E - This is essential to healthy skin growth and protects your skin. Avocado, pine nuts, and hazelnuts are great sources.

4. SELENIUM - Great for your immune system and skin health. Find it in eggs, tomatoes, wheat germ, shellfish, broccoli, and Brazil nuts.

5. ZINC - Helps your skin to repair and keeps it supple. Find it in lean meat, poultry, whole grains, fish, shellfish, nuts & seeds.



I'M NOT SHOUTING, IT'S JUST REALLY, REALLY IMPORTANT!

>> PLEASE WEAR SUNSCREEN <<

Every day, 365 days a year – come rain or shine. Obviously, if your scar isn't ever exposed to the sun, you can ignore this, but if it is – it's super important. When your skin is repairing, it's vulnerable to further damage.

The most common type of damage to the skin when it's recovering from trauma, is hyperpigmentation, from overexposure to UV rays.

If you expose your healing scars to the sun, you might experience something called 'post-inflammatory hyperpigmentation'.

This is where the skin around the scar (and sometimes the actual scar, depending on your natural skin type and tone), becomes much darker than your natural skin colour.

Your skin is desperately trying to protect the wound site, and sometimes – it can over produce melanin, which is your skin's natural defence to UV rays.

As a result, you can end up with a halo of hyperpigmented skin around your scars. In some cases, this can be permanent, in others – it will fade, but may take 2-3 years.



SCAR REDUCTION CREAMS

One of the most common things I am asked about is scar creams to help repair scarring. There are many on the market, and I'd recommend doing your own research – to see which might suit you best.

I personally have had great experiences with *RegimA Forte Scar Cream* (make sure you don't get the one that's just for stretch marks).

These creams work well and reduce inflammation, boosting collagen production and supporting your skin through healing.

Always patch test them before you use them, and do not apply to open skin. I would recommend consulting your GP or Consultant, before using any creams – just to be on the safe side.



SCAR COVER-UP - MAKE UP

I am not a fan of skin camouflage makeup, which is often thick, gloopy, and looks terrible when it's applied! I really love *Jane Iredale mineral makeup* though, which was originally designed as scar makeup and progressed to a beautiful cosmetic line.

Their mineral-based foundations, concealers and cover-ups provide excellent coverage and last much better than any gloopy skin camouflage makeup I've ever seen or used. The trick is to apply it in layers and fix with one of their sprays. It has amazing staying power, and many of my clients use it after treatments, whilst they are healing.



IN CONCLUSION

Patience really is key when it comes to scar healing. I know how hard this can be, as I've been there – MANY times!

Please be assured that there are some great treatments available to help you once you have recovered from the initial wound healing stage.

Once you have healed, then please get in touch, and book a consultation with me. We can then talk about the best approach for your scar transformation program.

I hope that this has been helpful, and you can take away some helpful tips and reassurance, that your scars can be improved.

I wish you a speedy recovery and look forward to hearing from you when you're ready to start treatment.

Kindest wishes, Nikki.

